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FRIDAY, FEBRUARY 28, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Ex-sailor pleads guilty to terror plot

Met with undercover FBI operative to discuss locations for an attack

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

A then-U.S. Navy sailor living at Naval Station Great Lakes in Chicago’s north suburbs met in October 2022 with someone he thought was an Iranian terrorist to discuss locations for an attack that would cause the maximum amount of carnage, federal investigators say.

During their conversation at the Lake Bluff train station, the sailor, Xuanyu Harry Pang, allegedly referenced surveillance photos he’d taken of Michigan Avenue in downtown Chicago on a busy afternoon.

“Remember, like you told me, like, you guys are looking for max damage, right?” Pang asked his accomplice, who was actually working undercover for the FBI. “You saw the street. It was packed. So think about it, like, if you have one guy just walking down the street, all of a sudden (rapid firing sound).”

That chilling conversation, secretly video recorded by the undercover operative, was included in court records unsealed Thursday showing that Pang helped plan a terrorist attack in the Chicago area in 2022 on behalf of Iran’s Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, purportedly to avenge the death of an Iranian general killed by U.S. forces.

Though Pang helped scout a number of locations, including the Magnificent Mile and the nearby Cloud Gate statue known as “the Bean,” the plot eventually coalesced around the Great Lakes base, where Pang and more than 20,000 other sailors were stationed, according to prosecutors.

Pang, 38, a naturalized U.S. citizen from China who immigrated here in 1998, admitted in a plea agreement with prosecutors that he took surveillance photos and videos of the outside and inside of the base and agreed to provide

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Brittany De Leon, center right, and Olivia Goldstein, both second and third grade teachers at Acero’s Santiago Elementary, embrace after the Chicago Board of Education voted Thursday to keep open a number of Acero schools through the 2025-26 school year. CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Board votes to keep Acero schools open

Amid financial warnings and after debate, sites get reprieve through 2025-26

By Nell Salzman
and Ikram Mohamed
Chicago Tribune

The Chicago Board of Education approved an amended resolution Thursday requiring Chicago Public Schools to keep open several charter schools slated for closure despite financial warnings that doing so would be unwise.

After a protracted and often confusing debate on the feasibility and fine print of the amendment, the school board voted 16 to 3 with one abstention to keep five of the seven schools slated for closure in Acero Charter Network open through the end of the 2025-26 school year

and incorporate them as district schools the next year. The board did not provide a concrete determination for the other two schools.

The last-minute change in the resolution also reflects the dynamics of a divided board — with several newly elected and appointed members — in a district facing serious financial challenges. The vote followed despairing pleas from throngs of parents and students in their schools’ T-shirts explaining how the closures would harm their families.

Thursday was the second time the board voted to keep open the schools through the 2025-26 school year. In December,

the board approved the same outcome, but the agenda for Thursday’s monthly meeting indicated that the board would vote to amend the resolution and close three of Acero’s schools, not two.

The amendment, posted 48 hours before the meeting, directed the district to keep just four schools open — a reduction from the original five — through at least the 2025-26 school year. However, the future of those schools in the next year was uncertain.

Several board members passionately discussed the financial decisions facing the board and acknowledged the devastation the closures would inflict

on the schools’ families and communities. However, most of the meeting’s public comment segment was taken up by Acero parents and students, who expressed their frustration — some with raised voices and tears — about the lack of communication from Acero leadership and their discomfort with the uncertainty they have faced for weeks.

“We’re broken due to this situation. I hope that no organization — be it charter or public — be so careless and reckless,” said Angelica Juarez, a parent at Acero’s Fuentes Elementary.

Acero charter schools are authorized and overseen by the

Turn to Schools, Page 5

Trump says tariffs will begin next week



President Donald Trump looks on during a joint news conference with U.K. Prime Minister Keir Starmer in the East Room at the White House on Thursday. ANDREW HARNIK/GETTY

Rate of 25% planned for Mexico, Canada, extra 10% for China

By Josh Boak
and Fabiola Sanchez
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump plans to impose tariffs on Canada and Mexico starting Tuesday, in addition to doubling the 10% universal tariff charged on imports from China.

In a Truth Social post Thursday, Trump said illicit drugs such as fentanyl are being smuggled into the United States at “unacceptable levels” and that import taxes would force other countries to crack down on the trafficking.

“We cannot allow this scourge to continue to harm the USA, and therefore, until it stops, or is seriously limited, the proposed TARIFFS scheduled to go into

Turn to Tariffs, Page 5

GENE HACKMAN
1930-2025



REED SAXON/AP 2003

Oscar winner shined in versatile roles

Beloved actor Gene Hackman and his wife were found dead in their Santa Fe, New Mexico, home. He was a frequent and versatile presence on screen from the 1960s until his retirement. His dozens of films included “The French Connection” and “Unforgiven.”

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In appreciation: In Gene Hackman, from Danville, the exquisite loneliness of the long-distance actor. Michael Phillips in A+E

TODAY’S WEATHER



High 57 Low 25

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
177th year No. 59 © Chicago Tribune

